Synthesis: what to fix

Every example here comes from your own papers, with the names taken off. Some sentences are the problem and some are the answer. Start with the top three. They'll change your next draft the most.

What's your point? So what? Who cares? Ask all three of every paragraph.

THE TOP THREE

1 Your best idea is buried. Find it and move it up.

You often find your real argument halfway through the draft and never go back for it. Reread, find the sentence where the idea first shows up, and build your thesis from it.

THESIS "Side by side, they show that people tried to escape the floods, which matters to the families of those affected, because they were unable to leave their homes and families."

PAGE 2 "Looking at these two references, it's easy to recognize that our system hasn't changed and continues to ignore lower income and minority communities." Same paper. This is the claim, and it belongs in the intro.

2 Name who is speaking.

Smith writes in many voices: the storm, the Superdome, the president, people left behind. The poet isn't the speaker, and one speaker isn't all of them.

BAD "Patricia Smith ("Man on the TV Say") and Charley Patton ("High Water Everywhere, Part 1") both cannot leave." The poet and the singer aren't stuck; the people in their works are.

BAD "Marty continues on 26 saying "tell them it's God"." That line sits with the officials' voice in "What to Tweak," not Marty's.

GOOD "Giving the storm a mind allows some of the blame to shift onto the storm itself, because the chaos created was due to the mind of the storm, rather than the Lord wanting to punish the people of Louisiana."

3 Let the two works differ. Read each one fairly.

Don't bend the older text until it matches Katrina. The differences are where the synthesis happens.

BAD "In the book of Genesis an entire group of people were attacked because of some people's wickedness." Genesis says "all flesh had corrupted its ways upon the earth" (6:12). Everyone, not some.

BAD "Gilgamesh acts as a representation of the average human" He's a king, and that's why his failure lands.

GOOD "While Egan points to the degradation of the Great Lakes as a matter of misled and uninformed actions, Smith describes the suffering in New Orleans as blatant dismissal and neglect of the people."

THE REST OF THE LIST

4 Make the thesis arguable.

A true description isn't a thesis. A reasonable reader has to be able to disagree.

BAD "These stories show that in extremely disastrous situations, many people are left without a path."

GOOD "When these sources are read together, they show how the United States government takes priority of one social class over the other, and how people of a lower status are left to figure out their own path through disaster."

5 Finish strong. Say what follows.

If your thesis is true, something follows from it. Say what, and don't end on a question.

BAD "Seeing how these injustices have still been shown in recent years, when will the government truly step in?"

GOOD "Recognizing water's significance requires more than acknowledging its power after disaster strikes. It requires respecting its vulnerability and understanding the consequences of human choices before the damage becomes impossible to ignore."

6 Give your title a second half.

The title should tell us what's coming.

BAD "Failure"

GOOD "A Disaster Within a Disaster: The Forgotten People of Katrina"

GOOD "The Visible and Invisible: How Humanity Reacts to Divinity During Disaster"

7 Use verbs that do something.

Show, focus on, showcase the theme of: these verbs say nothing. Name the action.

BAD "Charley Patton's song and Patricia Smiths collection of poems both showcase the theme of systemic neglect."

GOOD "This anger is grief. It burns and burns from a well of anguish, forcing the reader to feel its rage and sadness."

8 Say who did what to whom.

"Stuck," "abandoned," "they": someone did this. Put them in the sentence.

BAD "In this song Charley Patton is singing about going to a desirable place while being stuck in the floods." He sings "they got me barred." Someone barred him. Say who.

GOOD "In the middle of a disaster, the workers had to make the decision to leave without the elders, throwing all of their lives at Katrina's lethal hands."

9 Back up big claims. Don't overstate.

Claims about the world need evidence, and they need limits.

BAD "This was something commonly heard among these communities."

BAD "Hurricane Katrina destroyed the city of New Orleans in 2005." Much of the city, not all of it.

GOOD "Despite warnings about the potential threat, "The U.S. and Canadian governments did nothing with the information" (Egan 113)."

10 Quote exactly, from the page.

Nearly every paper dropped or swapped a word. Copy from the book, not from memory or notes.

PAPER "Pick y'all black asses and run."

SMITH "Pick up y'all black asses and run" (Smith 7).

PAPER "mad as God pointing the way out of Paradise"

SMITH "mad like God pointing the way outta Paradise" (Smith 7).

11 Punctuate quotations correctly.

Introduce the quote, close it, give the citation, then the period. Every quote needs a citation.

BAD "Never again shall I curse the ground because of humans" Said God

FIXED God says in his heart, "Never again will I curse the ground because of humans" (Genesis 8:21).

GOOD "The U.S. and Canadian governments did nothing with the information" (Egan 113).

12 Make transitions build.

"Another time..." and "Similarly..." just list. A good transition says how the next example builds on the last one.

BAD "Another time when abandonment occurs in Blood Dazzler is in the poem 34."

GOOD "Even worse may have been the human response to these invasions."

13 No comma splices.

Two complete sentences joined by a comma make a comma splice. Use a period or a semicolon, or add a joining word.

BAD "He is no stranger to abandonment, his fellow FEMA employees are watching from afar while he is trying to work on site."

FIXED He is no stranger to abandonment. His fellow FEMA employees are watching from afar while he is trying to work on site.

14 Use more of your evidence.

One poem against one song is thin. The rest of the book often makes your point for you.

BAD One paper criticized the president's flyover and never used Smith's poem about it, "The President Flies Over" (36).

GOOD Another set Ethel Freeman's sestina beside the residents of St. Rita's nursing home, then brought in a second blues song.

Quotations from student papers appear as written, errors included.